Walt Whitman Strides the Llano of New Mexico

By Rudolfo Anaya

"Chicano Child Enters University!" the papers cried.

Miracle child! Strange child!

Dark Child!

Speaks Spanish Child! Has Accent Child!

Needs Lots of Help Child! Has No Money Child!

Needs A Job Child! Barrio Child!

Poor People's Child! Gente Child!

Drop Out Child!

INTRODUCTION

*In "Walt Whitman Strides the Llano of New Mexico," (retired English professor) Rudolfo **Anaya** examines the impact of teachers and teaching on the lives of students, especially first-generation college students and minority students. In our "No Child Left Behind" society, Anaya's words speak clearly of the plight of the Chiano student to succeed in an educational world that has for too long closed the doors of opportunity.*

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I met Walt, kind old father, on the llano,
that expanse of land of eagle and cactus
Where the Mexicano met the Indio, and both met the tejano, along the Rio Pecos, our River of blood, River of Billy the Kid,
River of Fort Sumner where the Dine suffered, River of the golden Carp, god of my gods.

He came striding across the open plain,
There where the owl calls me to
the shrine of my birth,
There where Ultima buried my soul-cord, the blood, the afterbirth, my destiny.

His beard, coarse, scraggly, warm, filled with sunlight, like llano grass filled with grasshoppers, grillos, protection for lizards and jackrabbits, rattlesnakes, coyotes, and childhood fears.

"Buenos dias, don Walt!" I called. "I have been
waiting for you. I knew you would one day leap

across the Mississippi!
Leap from Manhattas! Leap over Brooklyn Bridge!
Leap over slavery!
Leap over the technocrats!
Leap over atomic waste!
Leap over the violence! Madonna!
Dead end rappers!
Peter Jennings and ungodly nightly news!

Leap over your own sex! Leap to embrace la gente
de Nuevo Mexico! Leap to miracles!"

I always knew that. I dreamed that.

I knew you would one day find the Mexicanos of my land,
the Nuevo Mexicanos who kicked *** with our Indian
ancestors, kicked *** with the tejanos,
And finally got their *** kicked by politicians!
I knew you would find us Chicanos, en la pobreza, Always
needing change for a ride or a pint,

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Pero ricos en el alma! Ricos en nuestra cultural Ricos can
suenos y memoria!

I kept the faith, don Walt, because I always knew you
could leap continents! Leap over the squalor! Leap over
pain and suffering, and the ash heap we Make of our
Earth! Leap into my arms.

Let me nestle in your bigote, don Walt, as lance nestled
in my abuelo's bigote, don Liborio, Patriarch of the
Mares clan, padre de mi mama, Farmer from Puerto de
Luna, mestizo de Espana y Mexico, Cat61ico y Judfo,
Moro y india, frances y mountain man, hombre de la
tierra!

Let me nestle in your bigote, don Walt, like lance nestled
in the grass of the llano, on summer days,
a child lost in the wide expanse, brother to lagarto,
jackrabbit, rattlesnake, vulture and hawk.
I lay sleeping in the grama grass, feeling

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the groan of the Earth beneath me, tierra sagrada!
Around me, grasshoppers chuffing, mockingbird calling,
meadowlark singing, owl warning, rabbit humping, flies
buzzing, worms turning, vulture and hawk
riding air currents, brujo spirits moving across
my back and raising the hair of my neck,
golden fish of my ponds tempting me to believe
in the gods of the earth, water, air and fire.
Oriente, poniente, norte, sur, y yo!
Dark earth groaning beneath me, sperm flowing,
sky turning orange and red, nighthawks dart, bats
flitter, the mourning call of La Llorona filling the night
wind as the *presence of the river* stirred, called my
name: "Hijo! Hiiiii-jo!"

And I fled, fled for the safety of my mother's arms.

You know the locura of childhood, don Walt
That's why I welcome you to the llano, my llano, My
Nuevo Mexico! Tierra sagrada! Tierra sangrada!

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Hold me in the safety of your arms, wise poet, old poet,
Abuelo de todos. Your fingers stir my memory.

The high school teachers didn't believe in the magic
of the Chicano heart. They fed me palabras sin sabor
when it was your flesh I yearned for. Your soul. They
teased us with "Oh, Capitan, My Capitan!" Read silently
so as to arouse no passion, no tears, no erections, no
bubbling love for poetry.

Que desgracia! What a disgrace! To give my soul only
one poem in four years when you were a universe!

Que desgracia! To give us only your name, when you were
Cosmos, and our brown faces yearned for
the safety of your bigote, your arms!

Que desgracia! That you have to leap from your grave,
Now, in this begetting time, to kick ass with this country
which is so slow to learn that

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we are the magic in the soul! We are the dream of Aztlan!

Que desgracia! That my parents didn't even know your name! Didn't know that in your *Leaves* of *Grass* there was salvation for the child.
I hear my mother's lament: "They gave me no education!" I understand my father's stupor: "They took mi *honor,* mi
orgullo, mi *palabra."*

Pobreza de mi gente! I strike back now! I bring you don Walt to help gird our loins!
Este viejo es guerrillero por la gente! Guerrillero por los pobres! Los de abajo!

Save our children now! I shout. Put *Leaves* of *Grass* in their lunchboxes! In the tacos and tamales!
Let them call him Abuelo! As I call him Abuelo!

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Chicano poets of the revolution! Let him fly with you As your squadrons of words fill the air over
AztLin! Mujeres chicanas! Pull his bigote as you Would tug at a friendly abuelo! His manhood is ours! Together we are One!

Pobreza! Child wandering the streets of Alburque! Broken
by the splash of water, elm seed ghost, lost and by winds
of spring mourned, by La Llorona of the *Rio* Grande
mourned, outcast, soul-seed, blasted by the wind
of the universe, soul-wind, scorched by the
Grandfather Sun, Lady Luna, insanity, grubs scratching
at broken limbs, fragmented soul.

I died and was buried and years later I awoke from
the dead and limped up the hill where your
Leaves of Grass lay buried in library stacks.

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Poor People's Child! Gente Child! Drop Out Child! "I'll show you," I sobbed, entering the labyrinth of loneliness,
dark shadows of library, cold white classrooms.

You saved me, don Walt, you and my familia which held
Me up, like a crutch holding the one-leg Man,
Like Amor holding the lover,
Like kiss holding the flame of Love.

You spoke to me of your Manhattas, working men and women, miracle of democracy, freedom of the soul, the suffering of the Great War, the death of Lincoln, the lilacs' last bloom, the pantheism of the Cosmos, the miracle of Word.

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Your words caressed my soul, soul meeting soul, You opened my mouth and forced me to speak!
Like a cricket placed on dumb tongue, Like the curandera's healing herbs and Touch which taught me to see beauty,
Your fingers poked and found my words! You drew my stories out.
You believed in the Child of the Llano.

I fell asleep on *Leaves of Grass,* covering myself with your bigote, dreaming my ancestors, my healers,
the cuentos of their past, dreams and memories.

I fell asleep in your love, and woke to my mother's tortillas on the comal, my father's cough, my familia's way to work, the vast love which was an ocean in a small house.

I woke to write my *Leaves of Llano Grass,* the cuentos of the llano, tierra sagrada! I thank the wise teacher who

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said, "Dark Child, read this book! You are grass and to grass you shall return."

"Gracias, don Walt! Enjoy your stay. Come again. Come Every day. Our nifios need you, as they need Our own poets. Maybe you'll write a poem in Spanish, I'll write one in Chinese. All of poetry is One."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rudolfo Anaya
Book: Anaya Reader
ISBN: 978-0446670777
Publisher: Warner Books
Date(Month/Year): April 1995

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier

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